

Cybersecurity Career Roadmap — From Zero to Job-Ready

2026 Edition • Beginner-friendly • India-focused, globally valid

Phase 0 — Foundations (Weeks 1–6)

You do not start with hacking. You start with how computers talk.

Area	What to learn	Free resources
Networking	TCP/IP, DNS, HTTP/S, OSI, ports, firewalls	Cisco Networking Academy, freeCodeCamp
Operating Systems	Linux command line, Windows basics, user permissions	Linux for Dummies, Microsoft Learn
IT Basics	Virtualization, CLI comfort, basic Python scripting	OpenStax, TheWire Bandit, Python.org

Phase 1 — Core Security (Weeks 7–16)

- Security principles: CIA triad, risk, authentication, encryption
- Web security: OWASP Top 10, HTTP requests, cookies/sessions
- Tools: Wireshark, Nmap, Burp Suite Community
- Practice: TryHackMe 'Complete Beginner' / 'Pre-Security', PortSwigger Web Academy

Phase 2 — SOC / Blue or Red path (Months 4–8)

Blue Team / SOC Analyst track (fastest entry in India): SIEM basics, log analysis, incident triage, MITRE ATT&CK.; Labs: LetsDefend, CyberDefenders, Splunk Fundamentals.

Red Team / Pentest track: Recon, scanning, exploitation, reporting. Labs: Hack The Box Academy, TryHackMe Offensive paths, DVWA/WebGoat.

Phase 3 — Specialize & Certify (Months 6–12)

Stage	Recommended certs	Notes
Entry / 0–1 yr	CompTIA Security+, Google Cybersecurity Certificate, Cisco CCNA	HFED only baseline
Core / 1–2 yr	CompTIA CySA+, CEH AI, Cisco CyberOps, eJPT	Hands-on SOC / pentest
Advanced	OSCP, CISSP (after 5yr), CCSE, CTIA	Specialization

Certifications validate skills, they do not replace them. Skill first, cert second.

Tools you will actually use

Ubuntu/Kali Linux, VirtualBox/VMware, Wireshark, Nmap, Burp Suite, Metasploit, Splunk/ELK, Git, VS Code. Cloud: AWS IAM basics, Docker.

Portfolio — 5 projects that get interviews

- 1. Home SOC lab: ingest logs into Splunk/ELK, write 3 detection rules with write-ups
- 2. Vulnerable web app audit: OWASP Top 10 findings with remediation report
- 3. Python network scanner / log parser on GitHub
- 4. Incident response playbook for phishing/ransomware, mapped to MITRE ATT&CK;
- 5. 1–2 responsible bug bounty reports or CTF write-ups

India job track

Entry roles: SOC Analyst L1, Vulnerability Analyst, Security Operations Trainee, GRC Analyst. Fresher ranges in India commonly quoted 6–12 LPA, mid 25–40 LPA with VAPT/cloud skills. Build LinkedIn/GitHub, 3 good projects beat 10 certificates.

12-week starter plan

Week	Focus	Output
Weeks 1–2	Networking + Linux CLI	2 hrs/day theory, 30 min labs
Weeks 3–4	Python basics + OS security	Automate 1 small task
Weeks 5–8	Web security + Burp/Nmap	Finish TryHackMe Pre-Security
Weeks 9–10	SIEM / incident response	LetsDefend 20 alerts
Weeks 11–12	Portfolio + Security+ prep	Publish 2 GitHub write-ups

Free lab stack

TryHackMe, Hack The Box Academy, PortSwigger Web Security Academy, OverTheWire, LetsDefend, CyberDefenders, OWASP Juice Shop, MITRE ATT&CK.;

Study rhythm that works

90 min theory → 60 min hands-on → 15 min notes. Consistency beats talent. 1.5–2 hrs/day for 6–9 months gets most career-switchers interview-ready.

Ethics

Only test systems you own or have written permission for. Learn to break things to protect them.

Generated June 2026 — Roadmap compiled from current community guides and EC-Council 2026 certification framework. Verify exam fees/dates before booking.